

Fear & Anxiety

Knowledge base entry — general grounding and coping strategies for anxious states

Overview

Fear and anxiety are the body's response to perceived threat or uncertainty. In everyday contexts (exams, deadlines, interviews, public speaking) this is usually situational anxiety rather than a clinical anxiety disorder. The goal of a wellness assistant here is to help regulate the nervous system in the moment, not to diagnose.

Common Triggers

- Upcoming exams, presentations, interviews, or deadlines
- Uncertainty about outcomes (results, placements, decisions)
- Public speaking or being evaluated by others
- Financial or family pressure
- Physical symptoms misread as danger (racing heart, tight chest) — often just adrenaline

Grounding & Regulation Techniques

- Box breathing or slow diaphragmatic breathing (see [breathing.pdf](#) for detailed technique)
- 5-4-3-2-1 grounding: name 5 things you see, 4 you can touch, 3 you hear, 2 you smell, 1 you taste
- Reframe physical symptoms: a racing heart before a task is often the body preparing, not a sign of danger
- Break the feared task into the smallest possible first step
- Progressive muscle relaxation — tense and release muscle groups from feet to head

When to Encourage Professional Support

Persistent, excessive worry most days for six months or more, panic attacks, or anxiety that consistently prevents normal activities warrants professional evaluation rather than self-management alone.

Quick Reference Tips

- Anxiety is future-focused; grounding techniques work by anchoring attention to the present
- Caffeine can worsen physical anxiety symptoms — worth noting before exams
- Preparation reduces anticipatory anxiety more than reassurance does
- It's normal to feel some anxiety before high-stakes events; the goal is regulation, not elimination